LETTER FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

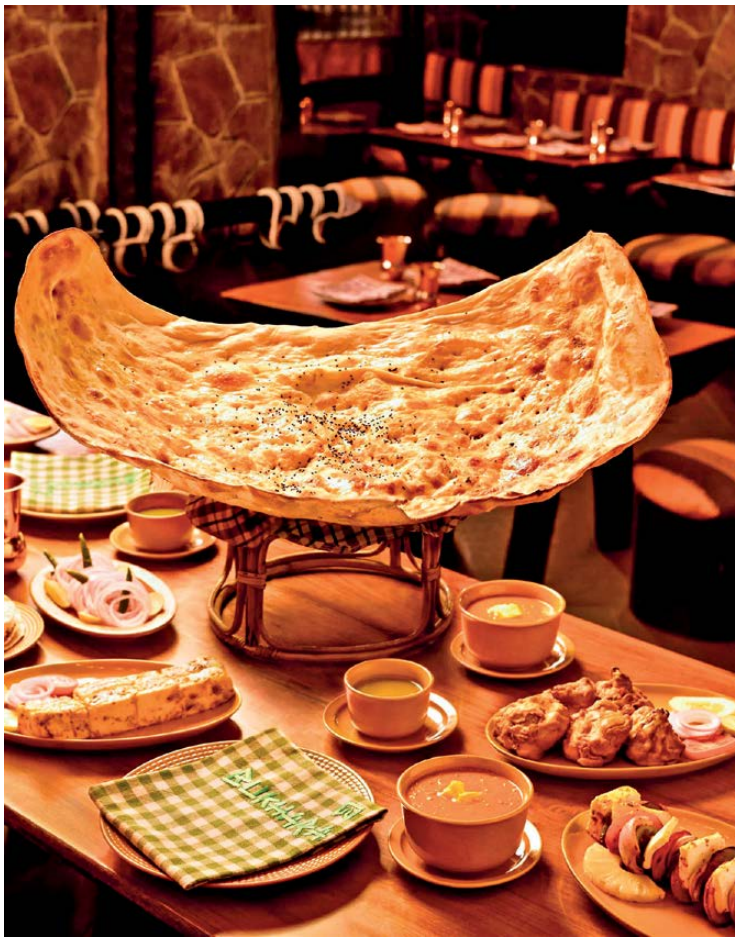
Milestone anniversaries always give us pause: to reminisce, recalibrate and of course celebrate. With *India Today* just having completed its 50th year, it seems almost serendipitous to have ITC Hotels, a peer brand that is also a product of the 1975 vintage, on our *Spice* cover for this Legacy special. A lasting legacy is a living evolution. It honours the past while boldly foraying into a relevant, ethical future.

Even as the hotel chain has grown to over 150 properties and more than 14,200 keys, this narrative goes beyond mere numbers. The stories of its international celebrity fandom have spurred a generation of urban legends. In an era of immersive technology, projection mapping and theatrical dining concepts, the charmingly old-fashioned concept of slow-cooked lentils and meat cooked over fire has spurred Bukhara's mythology around food that looks almost deliberately uncomplicated. Past famous guests, and storied narratives of iconic food, it's the credo of 'Responsible Luxury' that the hotel chain has come to embody. As early as 2011, it won the 'greenest luxury hotel chain in the world' award and today boasts of the world's largest number of LEED (Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design) Platinum certified hotels.

But it isn't just fine dining rooms that become part of a city's collective memory, our story on Geographical Indication (GI) tags as the new vanguard of 'Made in India,' celebrates India's design legacy. Geographic indication, woven into architecture, breathes a name into silent stone and transforms anonymous structures into living archives of cultural memory. They are no longer just marks of origin—they are the definitive blueprints for India's luxury and design evolution.

Fashion is also playing its part by transforming centuries of silent artistry with modern couturiers serving as revivalists of several Indian art forms, such as chikankari, kamdani, meenakari, block prints and zardozi, once patronised by India's royal families. Exquisite couture creations use these painstakingly labour-intensive arts, allowing authentic craft and artisans to flourish in a modern world.

The provenance of exquisite art relives its glory days in glasses too as the new speakeasy trend rewires India's 'clandestine' bars beyond tired clichés of hidden doors and hushed passwords toward avant-garde design, narrative-driven menus, and immersive sensory theatre. India's newest cocktail destinations are getting smaller, and thriving as bars inside bigger bars, usually in reservation-only formats. As storytelling outlines the vernacular of India's speakeasy movement, menus built around local ingredients celebrate India's geographical diversity through GI-tagged ingredients sourced from across the country.

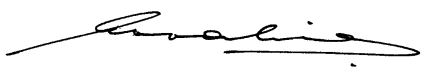


The storied Bukhara at ITC Maurya has acquired a legion of celebrity fans and its own urban legends.

In Delhi's Cavity, Sundarbans honey, Tripura's Queen Pineapple, Ladakhi apricots, Coorg coffee and Bhimkol bananas are being used not as exotic garnish but as the actual foundation of the experience. The speakeasy concept, long exhausted by hidden doors and hushed passwords, is being rewired into a concept that actually has something to say..

A lasting legacy, as this issue argues across every one of its pages, is not a fixed monument. It is a living evolution. It honours what was built while finding the courage to take it somewhere it has not been before.

Fifty years in, that remains the only kind of legacy worth having.



(Aroon Purie)